DAY 1 | EXCEL

My Data Analyst Journey

Excel Basics, Navigation & Formatting

Everything I learned today + the shortcuts
I will use every single day.

Ctrl Alt H F2

Swipe to learn with me >

Excel Basics

Why Excel and what is inside

Why Excel?

Every business (staff, marketing, owner, maintenance) runs on data.
Record it, analyze it, take the right decision.

Rows

1,048,576 rows - numbered 1, 2, 3 ...

Columns

16,384 columns - lettered A to XFD

Workbook

One file = one workbook. Inside it: many sheets (pages).

Data Entry

Number, Text, Date, Time. Record data in a clean, readable way.

Fill Series

Type 1, 2, 3 and drag the corner - the series can go on forever.

Know Your Interface

Where everything lives

Ribbon

Tabs > Groups > small arrow at the corner (Dialog Launcher) opens more options.

Name Box

Shows the address of the active cell, like A1.

Formula Bar

Type in the cell or the bar - both show the same thing.

Sheet Name

Double-click the sheet tab (or right-click > Rename) to change it.

Views

Normal view, Page Break / Print view, and Zoom (+ / -).

Alt Key

Press Alt to see Key Tips on the ribbon. H = Home tab.

Navigation

Move without the mouse

Next workbook	Ctrl + Tab
Task View (all windows)	Win + Tab
Next sheet	Ctrl + PgDn
Previous sheet	Ctrl + PgUp
Move right	Tab
Move down	Enter
Move left	Shift + Tab
Move up	Shift + Enter

Fast Move & Select

Jump around big data in seconds

Go to first cell (A1)	Ctrl + Home
Go to last used cell	Ctrl + End
Jump to edge of data	Ctrl + Arrow
Go To any cell (F5 too)	Ctrl + G
Select all data	Ctrl + A
Select till end of data	Ctrl + Shift + Arrow
Select cell by cell	Shift + Arrow
Edit cell (End = last letter)	F2

Ctrl+A and Ctrl+Shift+Arrow only travel through connected cells - they stop at a gap.

Rows & Columns

Select, insert, delete, resize

Select entire row	Shift + Space
Select entire column	Ctrl + Space
Insert row / column / cells	Ctrl + Shift + +
Delete row / column / cells	Ctrl + -
AutoFit row height	Alt + H + O + A
AutoFit column width	Alt + H + O + I
Fill down (Ctrl R = right)	Ctrl + D

Select first, then insert or delete. Double-click a column border for a quick AutoFit. Group sheets: click first, Shift+click last - one edit applies to all.

Font Formatting

Make your data readable

Bold (or Ctrl 2)	Ctrl + B
Italic (or Ctrl 3)	Ctrl + I
Underline (or Ctrl 4)	Ctrl + U
Strikethrough	Ctrl + 5
Change font style	Alt + H + F F
Change font size	Alt + H + F + S
Format Cells box	Ctrl + 1

Industry favourites: Calibri, Arial, Aptos, Segoe UI. Keep one font per sheet. Any font installed on your PC also shows in the list.

Alignment & Merge

Text sits left, numbers sit right

Center	Alt + H + A + C
Middle	Alt + H + A + M
Top align	Alt + H + A + T
Bottom align	Alt + H + A + B
Increase indent	Alt + H + 6
Wrap text	Alt + H + W
Merge & Center	Alt + H + M + C
Unmerge	Alt + H + M + U

Merge Across = Alt H M A, Merge Cells = Alt H M M. Merging keeps only the first cell (A1 + B1 = A1).

Borders & Colors

Alt activates, H opens Home

All borders	Alt + H + B + A
Thick outside border	Alt + H + B + T
More borders	Alt + H + B + M
No border	Alt + H + B + N
Cell (fill) color	Alt + H H
Font color	Alt + H + F + C
Format Painter	Alt + H + F + P
Paste Special	Ctrl + Alt + V

Cell color = paint bucket icon. Font color = letter A with a color bar. Copy a cell, select target, Paste Special > Formats.

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Number Shortcuts

Format numbers in one move

Number (1,000.00)	Ctrl + Shift + !
Currency	Ctrl + Shift + $
Percentage	Ctrl + Shift + %
General / normal	Ctrl + Shift + ~
Increase decimal	Alt + H + 0
Decrease decimal	Alt + H + 9
Date format	Ctrl + Shift + #
Time format	Ctrl + Shift + @

364335 is hard to read. 364,335.00 is easy.

Number Types

Currency, Accounting, Wrap & more

Currency

PKR 335.00 - symbol sits right next to the number.

Accounting

PKR 335.00 - symbol on the left edge, amount on the right edge.

Scientific

Long numbers (11+ digits) turn into 2E+11. Set the cell to Text first.

Wrap Text

Makes the cell taller so the text fits. Width stays the same.

Shrink to Fit

Makes the text smaller so it fits. Cell size stays the same.

Data Types

General, Number, Text, Date and Time.

Date Formats

Custom format codes

`DD-MM-YY`	10-10-26
`D-M-YY`	4-4-26
`DDD-MMM-YYYY`	Sat-Oct-2026
`DDDD-MMMM-YYYY`	Saturday-October-2026
`DD/MM/YYYY`	01/04/2026
`DD/MMM/YY`	01/Apr/26

Apply it: Ctrl+Space > Ctrl+1 > Custom > type the code in Type > OK.

Build Your Own Shortcut

Quick Access Toolbar trick

Step 1

Right-click any command (like Merge & Center) > Add to Quick Access Toolbar.

Step 2

Press Alt. A number appears on every icon in the toolbar.

Step 3

Press Alt + that number. That is your own shortcut!

Step 4

File > Options > Quick Access Toolbar to reorder. Order = number.

Put your most used command first - it becomes Alt+1.

Day 1
Done!

Navigation, selection, fonts, alignment,
borders, colors and number formats.

Which Excel shortcut saves you the most time?
Tell me in the comments.

Follow for Day 2

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